Handler from Talking With

By Jane Martin

INTRODUCTION

"And these signs shall follow them that believe; In my name shall they cast out devils; they shall speak with new tongues; They shall take up serpents; and if they drink any deadly thing, it shall not hurt them; they shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover," —Mark 16:17-18

To outsiders, mainstream Christians included, snake handling seems foolhardy at best and deadly at worst. And despite commending their desire to be obedient to Scripture, Christians have argued that snake handlers are wrong to take Jesus' words in Mark 16:17-18 literally. His statement, they argue, is not a commandment and, what's more, intentionally putting oneself in danger is tantamount to tempting God.

In Handler from the play Talking With, Jane Martin brings to the stage a young girl who devoutly believes in the Penacostal religion that deifies the act of snake handling. Handler by Jane Martin

A young woman in a simple, country-print dress. On the floor before her is a handmade wooden box about two feet long and eighteen inches high with a sliding wire screen top.

CARO: My Dada* was gonna do this tonight but the Lord froze his face so he sent me. I learned this from my Dada and he learned it up from great Gran, who took it on from the Reverend Soloman Bracewood, who had him a mule ministry 'round these parts way back when. Dada taught Miss Ellie, my rna, and my brother Jamie ... he was in it too, 'fore he went for Detroit.

See, what I got in here is snakes. Lotta people don't like snakes. Gives it its nature, I guess. This here is water mocs. Jamie, he said they got the dirtiest, nastiest bite of all ... well, rattlers is yer biggest. Lotta venom. You milk you a rattler, you can half fill up a juice glass. Dada said Jamie should do rattlers, but he never. Did 'heads, copperheads. Now they're slower and safer but it ain't such

FOR EDUCATIONAL

a good show. You know those dang snakes smell like cucumbers? Well, they do. Miss Ellie, she favored mocassins. Dada too ... well, Dada he did all kinds, all ways. Your mocassin now, he's your good 01' boy snake. Flat out mean an' lots of get up n' go. Heck, they'll chase ya. They will. 01' Dada he didn't like Miss Ellie doin' 'em. 'You layoff them mocs 'fore they lay you down.' Made Miss Ellie laugh. Lotta handlers think mocassins are slimy. Couldn't get me to touch one. They'll do rattlers ... got him a nice dry feel. Little bit sandpapery. Rattler can find ya in the pitch dark though. They git on to yer body heat. Snake handlin'. *All* my blood does it. Only Dada an' me now though. Snake handlin', with the Holiness Church. Down where I come from we take God pretty serious. If you got the spirit, snake don't bite. If he bites you, you know you ain't got the spirit. Makes the difference real clear, don't it?

It's right there in the scripture ... Mark, Chapter 16, verses 17 and 18, 'And these signs shall follow them that believe. In my name they shall cast out devils; they shall speak in new tongues; they shall take up serpents; and if they shall drink any deadly thing, it shall not hurt them; they shall lay hands on the sick and they shall recover.' Don't figure it could be much clearer than that. There's some churches don't use snakes, use strychnine, powdered poison, same idea though. They mix it with Cherry kool-ade, sing 'em a hymrn , drink it off, and then just stand around waitin' to see if they fall over. Ain't much of a show. Not like snakes. Dada does fire but I can't do it. Pours some kerosene in a coke bottle, sticks a rag in the top and lights it up. Holds that fire under his chin, passes it down the arm, puts his hand in it, you know, that kind of stuff. He says there's people do blow torches down to Tennessee. I don't know. Jamie give it a try 'fore he went to Detroit. Just about burned his ass off. Sorry.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

When I handle, I keep 'em in this box. Dada gimme this and some Heidi doll on my ninth birthday. Sometimes I'll just open up the lid and put my foot in or, uh, maybe stick it open side to my chest. There's some lay it to their face. I don't. Scares my eyes. Durin' service we take 'em right out, pass 'em around. It's more dangerous than a single handler. Snake gets to comparin' who got the spirit a whole lot an' who jes got it some. Somebody's jes about bound to come in second. Don't get me wrong now. Y' don't die every time yer bit. I been bit seven times. Four times by the same serpent. Dada says he got the sweet tooth for me. Dada been bit thirty-two times an' never saw him a doctor. Used to let me kiss him on the marks. Last one got him here. *(Points to eye.)* Froze him right up. Dada says he'll thaw but I don't know.

Day after Jamie took off Miss Ellie did mocassins standin' in the back of the pickup over to Hard Burley. Shouldn't ought to 'cause her mind weren't there. Coal truck backfired and she got bit. Snake bit her three more times 'fore she hit the ground. Dada layed hands on her but she died anyway. There was ten of us handled right there at the funeral. Snake handlin'.

Snake knows what you feel. You can fool a person but you can't fool a snake. You got the spirit, God locks their jaws. Keeps you safe. Tell you what though ... I don't believe in a God. Left me. Gone with Miss Ellie. I was handlin' when I knew it sure. Snake was jes comin' on down the line. Marita she yells out, 'The Lord. Lord's in me and with me. In me and with me.' Noah he was ululatin', talkin' in tongues. Couple of folks was rollin' and singing. Dada was doin' switch grips. Had Miss Ellie's weddin' ring on his little finger. And it came on me, heck, there ain't no God in here. There's just a bunch of shouters gettin' tranced. There ain't no God in here at all. 'Bout that time they layed that serpent to me. Felt fussy.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Nasty. Just lookin' for an excuse y'know? An' I was an empty vessel, worse nor a pharasee, grist for the mill. My blood went so cold I coulda crapped ice-cubes. Snake knew. Started to get leverage. So I said, 'Snake. You Satan' hand-maiden. You're right, there ain't no God in me. I'm just a woman, but I'm the only woman in my Dada's house and he needs me home. Outta his faith and his need, you lock yer jaws.' I let that snake feel a child's pure love and it sponged it up offa my hands and then 01' wiggley went limp. I tranced it. It was a real good service. Didn't nobody handlin' get bit. *(Takes snake out of the box.)* Yes, you got to believe. Holiness Church is dead right about that. Makes me wonder, you know? I git to lookin' at people and wonderin' if they got anything in 'em could lock a serpent's jaws. Any power or spirit or love or whatever. I look at 'em and I wonder, could they handle? Tell you what though, you can see it in a face. You can read it. You look me full in the face it don't take me 30 seconds. It's like I was the snake, some 01' pit viper, an' I can read yer heart. Maybe you could handle and maybe you can't, but there's but one sure thing in this world .. yer empty, yer gonna get bit.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jane Martin
Book: Talking With
ISBN: 978-0573630217
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Feb 2011

AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier